

# Global connectivity

The internet has changed the way people connect, share, and learn. In many countries, it's an essential tool for schools and businesses. However, only half the world's population is connected.

## A new human right

Mark Zuckerberg, the American founder of Facebook, argues that internet access should be considered a basic human right, just like healthcare or clean water. Access to the internet means access to knowledge. People in remote areas can find education, medical information, and weather data if they have a reliable internet connection. Small businesses can increase their visibility and reach more customers online. Zuckerberg founded the non-profit organization Internet.org to attempt to bring internet connectivity to people in developing countries.



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- ◀ 196–197 Social media platforms
- ◀ 212–213 Net neutrality

### REAL WORLD

## Project Aquila

Project Aquila is another Internet.org initiative. With a carbon-fibre body and a 34 m (111 ft) wingspan, Aquila is a solar-powered drone that acts as a moving cell tower located 18–28 km (11–17 miles) above ground. The goal is to create a network of drones in the stratosphere. The drones' mobility allows them to reach remote areas that don't have Wi-Fi access. Internet.org is also conducting research with high-energy lasers to increase transmission speeds.

### ◀ Free Basics

Free Basics is a partnership between Internet.org and phone companies within developing countries. The service allows users access to certain websites for free. This is great for users who can't afford a data plan, but some critics believe it affects net neutrality.

## Laptops for all

Since 2006, the non-profit initiative One Laptop Per Child (OLPC) has shipped its distinctive white and green XO laptops to kids all over the world. The XO is small, robust, can connect to the internet, and is packed full of educational potential. OLPC hopes that the laptops will give children the tools to learn and unlock their own educational potential, and provide an extra reason to bring increased internet connectivity to developing countries.

### ▷ Educational benefits

Communities with XO laptops report kids coming to school more often and staying in school longer. Students keep the laptops and can use them for homework and making school projects at night.

